

Parmesan Ice Cream

Makes between 1 and 1½ quarts ice cream

Cream (38%)

380g | 2 cups

Milk (37%)

370g | 1½ cups

Sugar (15%)

150g | ¾ cup

Glucose (5%)

50g | ¼ cup

Parmesan cheese (5%)

50g | ½ cup, freshly grated,
lightly packed

Texture agent of your choice
(see below)

TEXTURE AGENTS

① **Best texture**

Commercial stabilizer

3g | 1 teaspoon mixed with the
sugar before it is added to the
dairy.

② **Least icy**

Guar or xanthan gum

1g | ¼ teaspoon whirled in a
blender with the ice cream base
after it is chilled in the ice bath.

③ **Easiest to use**

Tapioca starch

5g | 2 teaspoons mixed with
20g | 2 tablespoons of cold milk,
whisked into the ice cream base
after it is finished cooking.

④ **Most accessible**

Cornstarch

10g | 1 tablespoon plus 1 teaspoon,
mixed with 20g | 2 tablespoons
of cold milk, whisked into the
simmering dairy, then cooked for
1 minute.

Parmesan ice cream is kind of “out there,” but I made a career in fine dining restaurants based on “out there” flavors. I found that for every “Oh, this flavor is unexpected, interesting, and pleasant to eat—just this once,” there was another flavor that made me think “Holy crap, why didn’t I think of this sooner?” Parmesan Ice Cream falls into this second category, and makes for a cheesy, nutty ice cream that is downright delicious. I bring it out for special moments, like when an apple crumble is coming out of the oven.

It doesn’t take much Parmesan cheese to flavor this ice cream, but it’s *gotta* be the good stuff. Splurge and buy the aged Parmigiano Reggiano they hold behind the cheese counter; for the love of all that is holy, don’t buy the pre-grated stuff! The surface of cheese starts to dry out when it is exposed to air, making it next to impossible to melt the cheese into your ice cream.

To blend the Parmesan into the ice cream base until smooth, you need the powerful blades of a blender, rather than a hand-blending wand. Still, even if all you have is a whisk, this ice cream can be made; you’ll just feel tiny flecks of the cheese when it’s frozen.

Boil the dairy. Place the cream, milk, sugar ①, and glucose in a medium heavy-bottomed saucepan over medium-high heat, and cook, whisking occasionally to discourage the milk from scorching, until it comes to a full rolling boil.

Add the cheese. Whisk in the cheese. Reduce the heat to a low simmer and continue cooking for 2 minutes ④, whisking frequently to prevent the cheese from settling to the bottom of the pot and scorching. Remove the pot from the heat ③.

Blend the cheese. Transfer the ice cream base to a blender and blend, starting on low speed and increasing gradually to high. Blend on high for 1 to 2 minutes, until the base is very smooth.

Chill. Immediately pour the ice cream base into a shallow metal or glass bowl. Working quickly, fill a large bowl two-thirds of the way with very icy ice water. Nest the hot bowl into this ice bath, stirring occasionally until it cools down ②.

Strain. When the base is cool to the touch (50°F or below), strain it through a fine-mesh sieve to remove any unblended cheese.

Cure. Transfer the base to the refrigerator to cure for 4 hours, or preferably overnight. (This step is optional, but the texture will be much improved with it.)

Churn. Place the base into the bowl of an ice cream maker and churn according to the manufacturer’s instructions. The ice cream is ready when it thickens into the texture of soft-serve ice cream and holds its shape, typically 20 to 30 minutes.

Harden. To freeze your ice cream in the American hard-pack style, immediately transfer it to a container with an airtight lid. Press plastic wrap directly on the surface of the ice cream to prevent ice crystals from forming, cover, and store it in your freezer until it hardens completely, between 4 and 12 hours. Or, feel free to enjoy your ice cream immediately; the texture will be similar to soft-serve.